

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Raat ko nacho, morning mein hospital jao (Dance in the evening and then get admitted to hospital in the morning)." That's Rakhi Sawant talking about how she got her breast implants. At Rs 2.5 lakh, the surgery was expensive, so she danced at a medical conference and earned enough tics for a doctor from Sweden to do the honours. In the age of 24-hour news television, if 27-year-old Sawant did not exist, she would have to be invented. Which other celebrity would admit to having had silicon implants to enhance her career, taking them out because they were bouncing too much while she rehearsed for Sony's ongoing reality dance show, *Nach Baliye 3*, and then wanting them back again? Which other star would sit in her borrowed Manish Malhotra finery on the couch on *Koffee with Karan* and scream as she did so: "*Hai, mera petticoat phat gaya* (my petticoat is torn)"? Which other actor-dancer would proudly point to the Botox jab on her face, one more nip and tuck in the continuing saga of Remaking Rakhi?

Whether she is haranguing her local corporator for leaving an open drain unattended outside her suburban Mumbai flat or sweetly encouraging her toyboy to rest a bit, whether she is speaking on an obscenity case registered against her in Kolhapur or attacking singer Mika for thinking he could get away with kissing her, Sawant is a latter-day Houdini, escaping the limits of her deprivation and the lack of education to sing, dance, sob and snifle her way through reality shows, news telecasts and tiny roles in films, leaving far behind the steamy music videos of her Remix Rani phase. It's easy to say she turned one accident to her advantage—what the safety pin Versace dress did for Elizabeth Hurley, the Mika kiss did for Sawant. Here was a woman from the Mallika Sherawat school of self-marketing who turned a personal outrage into a public circus, becoming in the process a reality TV star and one **BOLD AND BOUNTIFUL: Her full-on act on *Bigg Boss* won her many fans**

"My family was the kind where the women had big moustaches. If I ever stood in the balcony, I would get beaten up."



DRAMA QUEEN

Botox, breasts, boyfriends. She may have fake body parts but everything else, especially the hard work, is genuine. Meet Rakhi Sawant, who has gone from no-name to fame in the span of a year by being the star of her very own continuing daily soap.